

****Us and Privacy, Scorza: No to "Digital Love Proofs" that Take Away Freedom and Privacy****

The column of the insert **Noi Magazine**, in collaboration with the Italian Data Protection Authority, helps young people (and not only) to navigate the web with more security and responsibility every week: in the latest issue, lawyer Guido Scorza, a member of the GPDP, intervened.

****Intervention by Guido Scorza, Member of the Italian Data Protection Authority****

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Times are changing, and the digital world is increasingly taking over our lives, regardless of age and context. Romantic affairs among adolescents are no exception to this rule and, more and more frequently, they begin, grow, and inevitably sometimes end mediated by a smartphone, a chat, a social network, or an app.

So far, nothing really strange, even if it may seem so to us adults who experienced the same stage of life in a completely different way. However, it is one thing not to be surprised or worried about the new myriad forms of first loves or the fact that the time of apples has become that of smartphones, chats, and socials; it is another thing to underestimate certain drifts that have nothing to do with love.

****Proofs that are not Love: Videos and Traps****

This is the case with the new digital love proofs that are increasingly being requested among adolescents. These new pseudo-proofs of love vary among themselves but have one constant: they do not prove love but, at most, its absence, and they are damned dangerous or, at least, can become so. The most popular one generally starts like this: "I miss you, come on, if you love me send me a photo of you while you undress." Naturally, often in a different language than this and not limited to asking the other to undress in front of the smartphone. The request is usually followed by a promise: "I will keep what you send me just for us."

But then, we know how love stories go, or those flings that we always – and even more often as adolescents – confuse for love stories: sometimes they end, and it is rare that they end for both at the same moment, that one breaks up with the same state of mind, that both continue to care for and respect each other. And then it happens that those videos, those photos, those suggestive laughs take unimaginable directions, end up in a chat populated by friends or self-proclaimed ones, or maybe on social media, or perhaps on porn sites, in exchange for other photos. There is no need to linger on what the impact can be on a girl or boy if a sexually explicit photo or video of theirs becomes public because it is easy to imagine.

****Passwords: Better to Keep Them to Ourselves****

But there are even more "sly" proofs of love that are much harder to recognize as dangerous. "I'm jealous, who are you chatting with all day? Who are you exchanging those photos with? If you want me to trust you, give me your social media password; after all, if you are faithful, you have nothing to hide." Most of the time, the request follows a fight, a skirmish between lovers, or an episode that has ignited one of their jealousy. And often one ends up giving in to the request, also because the mistaken perception of not really having anything to hide is widespread even among adults. So, who cares if he or she can read my messages: "I have nothing to hide." But that's not true. Gabriel Garcia Marquez wrote it among the first: "We all have three dimensions of life: a public one, a private one, and a secret one." Opening our social media to someone close to us at a certain moment in our life is simply a bad idea. And not only because it is natural that there will come a time when we would like to confide in a friend and we would like to reclaim a digital space for our intimacy, but also because the risk of misunderstandings, in every form of communication, is always lurking, especially in the terse and cryptic communications based on acronyms, initials, hashtags, and emojis that characterize social media even more. It is hard to imagine the consequences of a misunderstanding from the other person. The most innocent of our messages can trigger episodes of jealousy that are not always easy to manage, hurt the other's pride, instill doubts of every kind, and, unfortunately, in some cases, unleash violence, the feeling farthest from love. No, definitely, sharing the password of one's social media or messaging apps with a partner is not a proof of love. In fact, do yourself a favor: if you have

already done it, tell your partner that the real proof of love is mutual trust and that you read somewhere that exchanging passwords is wrong and dangerous for both, and then change the password and reclaim your freedom.

****Geolocation: Control and Pitfalls****

But technology and digital habits are moving fast, and the exchange of passwords is becoming an obsolete non-proof of love. Indeed, there are now apps capable, in just a few clicks, of allowing anyone to monitor our movements step by step, where we are, and, in some cases and with certain limits, even who we are with and for how long. Sometimes, there is no need for a specific app because there are messaging apps that allow sharing one's location in real time. And so, unfortunately, it is no longer uncommon for the requested proof of love to be precisely this: "Let me install an app like this on your smartphone or share your real-time location with me, so I will always know where you are, and we will be more at ease." Yes, it seems true, easy, and harmless, but then comes the moment when it would be...

better that he or she does not know where we are, also in this case, for various reasons, not necessarily malicious: because we do not want to tell her or him that we went to the hospital for a check-up, that we went to give her or him a gift, that we left school early for any reason. And at that point, we would feel prisoners of our proof of love also because if we tried to deactivate the app, it would inevitably lead to the thought that we must have something to hide.

Once again, therefore, it is not a proof of love but a form of unsustainable limitation of our freedom, and if one does not feel free while loving, perhaps one does not love or is not loved. It is better not to yield even to the request for this pseudo-proof of love if it arrives, while if it has already arrived and we have already yielded, it is worth doing as above: "I read that it is wrong and dangerous, call me or send me a message whenever you want and I will tell you where I am, and if we want to see each other, I will share my location snapshot and not in real time on WhatsApp or elsewhere, but I will uninstall your app!"

Love, fortunately, even in the digital dimension, is more beautiful than this and deserves to be lived rather than becoming the object of this or that proof.